

The Narcissistic Advantage:
How Confidence, Relentlessness, and Low Constraint Can Pay in
Careers and Litigation

Annotated Bibliography and Critical Synthesis

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Scope, Terminology, and Working Thesis

This bibliography asks a deliberately uncomfortable question: when can psychologically narcissistic traits function as an advantage? Its central claim is not that narcissistic personality disorder (NPD) makes a person more competent, ethical, or deserving of success. Rather, many institutions reward the behavioral signals associated with grandiose narcissism—visible confidence, dominance, self-promotion, ambitious goal pursuit, resistance to disapproval, risk tolerance, and persistence—before they can accurately assess competence, judgment, or character. Those signals can become career capital in hiring, promotion, leadership selection, client acquisition, negotiation, and other settings marked by uncertainty and competition.

The proposed legal-system advantage is more specific. Litigation often converts persistence into bargaining power because continuing a dispute imposes costs on opponents as well as on the person who continues it. A litigant who is unusually confident, comparatively insensitive to social disapproval, willing to accept risk, resistant to expert advice, and reluctant to settle may outlast a less-resourced opponent, create delay, or make capitulation economically rational. In that limited sense, relentlessness can produce leverage even when the underlying claim is weak. Courtroom confidence and forceful speech may also influence credibility judgments, while occupational stereotypes may make antagonistic traits appear compatible with legal work.

The evidence does not establish that people with NPD routinely file frivolous lawsuits, pursue meritless appeals, intimidate decision makers, or win more cases. The strongest direct study concerns corporate exposure to lawsuits and settlement resistance, not habitual plaintiff litigation. Accordingly, this paper treats frivolous filing, repeated appeals, and intimidation as

testable extensions of the documented mechanisms—not as settled facts. It also distinguishes reduced guilt proneness from an absolute “lack of guilt,” discounting advice from a blanket refusal to obey authority, and emotional detachment from an absence of emotion. Narcissistic individuals can be highly emotional, especially when status or self-image is threatened.

Throughout, narcissism refers primarily to continuously measured grandiose traits in nonclinical samples. NPD is a clinical diagnosis requiring pervasive patterns and impairment; it cannot be inferred from confidence, aggression, litigation, or career success alone. This distinction is essential because the empirical literature generally measures traits with self-report instruments, observer ratings, or executive proxies rather than diagnosing NPD.

I. Conceptual Foundation

Miller, J. D., Lynam, D. R., Hyatt, C. S., & Campbell, W. K. (2017). Controversies in narcissism. *Annual Review of Clinical Psychology*, 13, 291–315.

<https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-clinpsy-032816-045244>

This review clarifies why “narcissism” cannot be treated as a single, uniformly pathological condition. The authors synthesize disputes over grandiose and vulnerable narcissism, normal-range traits and clinical disorder, self-esteem, empathy, interpersonal antagonism, and measurement. Grandiose narcissism combines assertive, agentic qualities with entitlement and antagonism; vulnerable narcissism is more strongly associated with insecurity and negative affect. NPD may contain features of both, but a trait score is not a diagnosis.

The article supplies the paper’s conceptual guardrail. Traits such as boldness, dominance, and reward seeking can be adaptive in one environment while entitlement, exploitation, and low communion damage relationships in another. This makes

“advantage” conditional rather than global: narcissistic traits may improve entry, visibility, or leverage while reducing accuracy, cooperation, and long-term trust. As a broad review, the article does not test career or legal outcomes directly, but its distinctions prevent the present argument from romanticizing NPD or confusing assertiveness with pathology.

Carlson, E. N., Vazire, S., & Oltmanns, T. F. (2011). You probably think this paper's about you: Narcissists' perceptions of their personality and reputation. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 101(1), 185–201. <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0023781>

Across three studies and several relationship contexts, the authors compared narcissistic individuals' self-perceptions, beliefs about how others viewed them, and other people's actual impressions. Higher narcissism predicted favorable self-views and positive first impressions, but acquaintances' evaluations became more negative over time. Participants high in narcissism showed partial awareness of both their favorable initial impact and their deteriorating reputations.

This temporal pattern is central to the narcissistic-advantage thesis. Many consequential gates—interviews, client consultations, campaign appearances, preliminary negotiations, and brief hearings—reward immediate presence rather than longitudinal reliability. A person can therefore receive repeated short-term benefits by moving among new audiences even if coworkers or close associates later become less impressed. The study does not show that narcissists are more successful overall, and its interpersonal findings should not be assumed to transfer automatically to judges or jurors. It nevertheless identifies a credible selection mechanism: institutions may reward an early confidence signal before accumulating enough evidence to correct it.

II. Career Advancement: Visibility, Motivation, and Power

Grijalva, E., Harms, P. D., Newman, D. A., Gaddis, B. H., & Fraley, R. C. (2015). Narcissism and leadership: A meta-analytic review of linear and nonlinear relationships. *Personnel Psychology*, 68(1), 1–47. <https://doi.org/10.1111/peps.12072>

This meta-analysis separates leadership emergence—being seen or selected as a leader—from leadership effectiveness. Narcissism was positively associated with leadership emergence but showed no simple positive relationship with effectiveness. The authors also found evidence of a nonlinear pattern in which moderate narcissism could be evaluated more favorably than very low or very high levels.

The distinction explains how narcissistic traits can aid careers without producing superior performance. Extraversion, dominance, and confidence help a person claim attention, speak first, and look leader-like; those behaviors affect who obtains authority. Once performance depends on collaboration, judgment, and sustained relationships, the advantage can flatten or reverse. Meta-analysis strengthens generalizability, but the component studies differ in measures and contexts. The article therefore supports a selection advantage, not the claim that extreme narcissism creates better leaders.

Hirschi, A., & Jaensch, V. K. (2015). Narcissism and career success: Occupational self-efficacy and career engagement as mediators. *Personality and Individual Differences*, 77, 205–208. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2015.01.002>

Using data from 314 employees, Hirschi and Jaensch examined narcissism, occupational self-efficacy, career engagement, and subjective and objective indicators of career success. Narcissism showed small positive relationships with career outcomes, and

the proposed pathways ran through confidence in occupational capability and active investment in career development.

The study reframes apparent “relentlessness” as an empirically measurable process: people who expect themselves to succeed may pursue opportunities, negotiate, network, and recover from rejection more aggressively. Those repeated actions can compound into advantage. The cross-sectional design, however, cannot establish whether narcissism caused success or whether success reinforced narcissistic self-beliefs; self-report measures also invite shared-method bias. The article supports a motivational pathway rather than an inherent superiority pathway.

Nevicka, B., & Sedikides, C. (2021). Employee narcissism and promotability prospects. *Journal of Personality*, 89(4), 847–862. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jopy.12619>

Across multisource field data and an experiment, the authors investigated why narcissistic employees may appear promotable. Narcissism predicted a stronger sense of power and more visible displays of power, which in turn shaped promotability judgments. The results point to enacted dominance rather than self-promotion alone as the signal evaluators reward.

This research provides one of the clearest institutional mechanisms in the bibliography: advancement decisions can be influenced by how powerful a person appears before the person possesses formal authority. That appearance may be especially advantageous in competitive professions, including law, where decisiveness, command, and willingness to challenge others are culturally legible as competence. The studies concern perceived promotability, not subsequent performance, ethics, or actual promotion

over many years. Thus, they explain access to power more convincingly than responsible use of power.

Leder, J., Foster, J. D., & Schütz, A. (2020). Willing to do what others won't: Narcissism, risk-taking, and social approval. *Personality and Individual Differences*, 153, Article 109672. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2019.109672>

Leder and colleagues reanalyzed a dataset of 605 American university students who completed measures of narcissism and willingness to engage in 30 forms of risk-taking. An independent sample rated the social approval attached to those behaviors. Narcissism was more strongly associated with socially disapproved risks than with approved risks, although the moderation was weak. The analysis suggested that participants higher in narcissism allowed social disapproval to reduce perceived benefits less strongly than other participants did.

This result gives precision to the idea that narcissistic actors will do what others will not. The relevant advantage is not emotional emptiness; it is reduced behavioral constraint from anticipated disapproval. In careers, that may support bold asks, norm-breaking political tactics, or repeated applications after rejection. In disputes, it may lower the social cost of appearing unreasonable or aggressive. Yet the sample was young, outcomes were hypothetical self-reports, and the study did not measure litigation or success. It supports a risk-and-disapproval mechanism, not proof that socially disapproved conduct pays.

Szabó, Z. P., Diller, S. J., Czibor, A., Restás, P., Jonas, E., & Frey, D. (2023). “One of these things is not like the others”: The associations between dark triad personality traits, work

attitudes, and work-related motivation. *Personality and Individual Differences*, 205, Article 112098. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2023.112098>

Across two studies with a combined 688 participants, the authors compared narcissism, Machiavellianism, and psychopathy as predictors of work attitudes and motivation. Narcissism stood apart from the other Dark Triad traits: it was consistently associated with more positive work-related motivation and attitudes, whereas psychopathy was generally negative. The second study included self- and observer reports, which correlated only weakly and underscored the importance of who is doing the rating.

This study complicates a purely deficit-based portrait. Ambition, engagement, organizational identification, or satisfaction can make a narcissistic employee work intensely toward visible goals; persistence may therefore be genuine rather than merely performed. At the same time, favorable self-reports do not establish productivity or prosocial commitment, and the weak agreement between self- and other ratings warns against taking narcissistic self-assessment at face value. For the present thesis, the study supports strong approach motivation, not “lack of emotion,” and helps distinguish narcissism from psychopathy.

O'Reilly, C. A., III, & Pfeffer, J. (2021). Organizational power and politics: The narcissist's advantage? *Personality and Individual Differences*, 182, Article 111061. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2021.111061>

O'Reilly and Pfeffer tested whether narcissism predicts willingness to use organizational politics to gain power. In a sample of 270 adults, higher narcissism was associated with greater endorsement of aggressive, self-serving, and norm-violating

political tactics. Lower guilt proneness strengthened important parts of this relationship, suggesting that reduced anticipated remorse can remove a constraint on conduct that others avoid.

This is the closest theoretical foundation for a narcissistic advantage, but the present project extends it in a different direction. The original article addresses general workplace politics; this bibliography connects the same low-constraint pattern to career gates and to adversarial legal procedures. It proposes that confidence, power displays, disapproval-resistant risk, and settlement resistance can become institutional leverage. Because the study measured attitudes toward tactics rather than verified long-term gains, it cannot show that aggression actually produces durable success. Ethical sanctions, damaged trust, and overreach remain plausible reversals.

Zhang, C., & Wei, X. (2024). Differentiating the effects of power and status on unethical behavior: A moderated mediation meta-analysis. *Journal of Business and Psychology*, 39(4), 871–896. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10869-023-09919-2>

This moderated mediation meta-analysis synthesizes 132 samples reported in 95 articles. Power and status had different relationships with unethical behavior: power was positively associated with unethical behavior, whereas status was negatively associated. Moral cognition helped explain both relationships, and the indirect effects were stronger in higher-power-distance settings.

The study does not measure narcissism, so it should not be presented as evidence that narcissistic people necessarily act unethically. Its value is institutional. If narcissistic confidence and dominance help a person acquire discretionary power, power may then amplify low-constraint behavior by changing moral cognition and reducing inhibition.

Status can operate in the opposite direction because reputation and others' respect impose accountability. This distinction improves the argument: the narcissistic advantage is likely greatest where a person has power over resources or procedure without equivalent reputational oversight.

III. The Legal System: Credibility, Persistence, and Procedural Leverage

Kay, C. S., & Saucier, G. (2020). Insert a joke about lawyers: Evaluating preferences for the Dark Triad traits in six occupations. *Personality and Individual Differences*, 159, Article 109863. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2020.109863>

In a sample of 933 participants, Kay and Saucier examined which Dark Triad characteristics people considered desirable or acceptable in several occupations. Respondents treated some antagonistic characteristics as more compatible with lawyers than with many other roles. The result concerns occupational stereotypes: observers may believe that toughness, strategic self-interest, or interpersonal coldness fits adversarial legal work.

Stereotypes can create a selection advantage because applicants who display confidence, dominance, and strategic aggression may look like the expected kind of lawyer. Clients may make a similar inference when choosing counsel. The study does not show that lawyers are more narcissistic, that these traits improve legal performance, or that observers can distinguish narcissism from ordinary assertiveness. It nevertheless demonstrates a cultural permission structure in which behavior penalized elsewhere can be interpreted as professional fit.

Erickson, B., Lind, E. A., Johnson, B. C., & O'Barr, W. M. (1978). Speech style and impression formation in a court setting: The effects of "powerful" and "powerless" speech. *Journal*

of *Experimental Social Psychology*, 14(3), 266–279. [https://doi.org/10.1016/0022-1031\(78\)90015-X](https://doi.org/10.1016/0022-1031(78)90015-X)

This courtroom experiment tested the effects of powerful and powerless speech styles on impression formation. Speech containing fewer hedges, hesitations, intensifiers, and deferential forms produced more favorable judgments of credibility and competence. The study therefore shows that legal evaluation can be shaped by delivery as well as by substantive content.

The paper does not measure narcissism, but it identifies a mechanism through which narcissistic self-certainty may be rewarded. A litigant or advocate who speaks without visible doubt can appear more credible even when confidence is not calibrated to evidence. This is particularly relevant in short encounters, where decision makers lack longitudinal information. The study is older and uses controlled materials rather than the full complexity of contemporary trials, so it should support a narrow point about impression formation—not a claim that confident speakers always persuade judges or juries.

O'Reilly, C. A., III, Doerr, B., & Chatman, J. A. (2018). “See you in court”: How CEO narcissism increases firms’ vulnerability to lawsuits. *The Leadership Quarterly*, 29(3), 365–378. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.leaqua.2017.08.001>

This article offers the bibliography’s most direct connection between narcissism and litigation. A field study of 32 high-technology firms, using employee ratings of CEOs, found that firms led by more narcissistic CEOs were involved in more lawsuits and that those lawsuits lasted longer. Two experiments then examined mechanisms. Participants higher in narcissism were more willing to approve legally questionable

actions, less sensitive to objective risk, more confident in their performance, less trusting of expert advice, and—when the chance of losing was high—less willing to settle.

The findings support a persistence-to-leverage pathway: overconfidence and expert discounting can keep a dispute alive after a more cautious actor would compromise. Protracted litigation imposes costs on opponents and can change settlement incentives, so stubbornness may occasionally secure delay, capitulation, or a favorable bargain. That is a procedural advantage, not necessarily a just result or a victory on the merits. The field sample was small and industry-specific, and the experiments did not test habitual plaintiffs, frivolous filings, appeals, or intimidation. Those behaviors remain plausible hypotheses rather than demonstrated consequences.

Eigen, Z. J., & Listokin, Y. (2012). Do lawyers really believe their own hype, and should they? A natural experiment. *The Journal of Legal Studies*, 41(2), 239–267.

<https://doi.org/10.1086/667711>

Eigen and Listokin used a natural experiment involving law students to examine whether advocacy roles generate overconfidence. Participants came to believe more strongly in the positions they were assigned to advocate, showing that professional role and motivated reasoning can alter judgment. Importantly, greater overconfidence was associated with poorer advocacy performance rather than superior outcomes.

The article supplies an essential counterweight. Legal institutions do not merely reward preexisting narcissistic confidence; adversarial roles can also manufacture self-belief. Confidence may impress clients or counterparties while simultaneously weakening settlement calibration and evidence assessment. Consequently, refusal to concede is not reliable proof of strength. The study concerns law students and a bounded exercise, so

generalization to experienced attorneys and litigants requires care, but it demonstrates why subjective certainty must be separated from legal accuracy.

Critical Synthesis: The Conditional Narcissistic Advantage

Taken together, the research supports a conditional advantage model rather than a celebration of narcissism. First, grandiose narcissistic traits generate highly visible signals: confidence, dominance, ambitious approach motivation, power displays, willingness to take disapproved risks, and reduced anticipated guilt. Second, evaluators use those signals as shortcuts when information is scarce. Positive first impressions, leader emergence, promotability, and lawyer stereotypes show how apparent power can be mistaken for probable competence. Third, favorable perceptions become resources—interviews, clients, authority, information, money, and procedural discretion—that allow the person to pursue goals more effectively. The advantage is therefore institutional: it arises when a setting converts a style of self-presentation into access.

The legal pathway adds a fourth stage: persistence can become leverage. Litigation distributes burdens across parties. Continuing to file motions, resist settlement, demand discovery, or pursue review requires resources, but it also consumes an opponent's time and money. The O'Reilly, Doerr, and Chatman findings directly document more and longer corporate lawsuits, high-risk settlement resistance, and distrust of experts. Leder and colleagues show reduced constraint from social disapproval; O'Reilly and Pfeffer identify aggressive political tactics and low guilt proneness; Erickson and colleagues show that confident speech affects courtroom impressions. Combined, these findings make it reasonable to hypothesize that a self-certain, disapproval-resistant litigant may treat endurance itself as strategy.

That strategy can “work” in several morally and legally distinct senses. It may produce a favorable merits judgment, but it can also secure delay, increase an opponent’s costs, force a nuisance-value settlement, deter future challenges, preserve public appearance, or exhaust someone who cannot afford to continue. The last outcomes are victories of asymmetry rather than evidence. This distinction explains why a person may appear repeatedly successful even when courts reject some claims: the operative payoff may occur outside the final judgment. It also clarifies how self-righteousness can matter. Certainty in one’s own entitlement may authorize escalation internally, while forceful presentation communicates that escalation externally.

However, the present literature does not demonstrate the complete chain from narcissistic trait to frivolous lawsuit, appeal, intimidation, and ultimate success. Direct evidence is limited to corporate litigation exposure and settlement decisions. Judges can impose sanctions, courts can restrict vexatious litigants, ethical rules can discipline attorneys, and resource limits can make persistence self-destructive. Moreover, Carlson and colleagues show that favorable impressions deteriorate; leadership research separates emergence from effectiveness; Eigen and Listokin link overconfidence with poorer advocacy; and Zhang and Wei show that status can inhibit unethical behavior even when power encourages it. Reputational memory, expert review, transparent records, calibrated sanctions, and meaningful cost shifting are therefore likely to reduce the advantage.

The most defensible conclusion is that narcissistic traits can be selectively rewarded at the stages where confidence, visibility, and willingness to impose costs matter more than humility, accuracy, or cooperation. This may help some people gain positions, command attention, and hold disputes open longer than others would. It does not establish that NPD causes

life success, that people with NPD lack emotion or guilt, or that legal institutions simply surrender to them. The “narcissistic advantage” is best understood as a mismatch between what institutions initially reward and what competent, ethical, long-term performance actually requires.

Directions for Further Research

A rigorous test of the legal hypothesis should follow litigants and attorneys over time and distinguish grandiose traits, vulnerable traits, antagonism, psychopathy, ordinary assertiveness, and diagnosed NPD. Outcomes should include claim merit, filing frequency, motions and appeals, settlement timing, sanctions, disciplinary history, total litigation cost, objective case results, client acquisition, peer trust, and opposing-party burden. Researchers should also record whether apparent “success” reflects judgment on the merits, settlement, delay, withdrawal by an exhausted opponent, or simple survival of the dispute.

The design should test moderators that determine whether confidence becomes capital: evaluator familiarity, judicial case management, fee shifting, representation status, resource inequality, public visibility, practice area, organizational power, reputational status, and access to expert advice. Such evidence could reveal when persistence protects legitimate rights and when procedure unintentionally rewards coercive endurance. Until then, the strongest claim is a mechanism-based one: narcissistic traits may create an advantage when systems reward bold signals and allow one actor’s persistence to externalize costs onto others.